

## Chapter 2: ***Entry-Level Requires Experience in Surviving Life***

The first email arrived at 8:14 a.m.

She stared at it for a long time without opening it.

“It’s a rejection,” Mia said from the kitchen.

“I haven’t opened it yet.”

“I can feel it.”

“That’s not how emails work.”

Mia sipped coffee. “And yet I’m always right.”

That was the problem.

Mia was *always* right.

And somehow, that had never felt suspicious before.

She opened the email.

**“Thank you for your application. Unfortunately…”**

She didn’t finish reading it.

She didn’t need to.

Mia nodded once, like a doctor confirming a diagnosis.

“Told you.”

“You didn’t even read it.”

“I read energy.”

“That’s not a thing.”

Mia looked at her. “It is if you’re unemployed long enough.”

By 10 a.m., she had applied to seven more jobs.

By 10:15, she regretted existing professionally.

By 10:16, Mia had already renamed her CV file to:

**“PLEASE HIRE ME I HAVE EMOTIONAL POTENTIAL.pdf”**

She stared at her laptop.

“I did not name it that.”

Mia didn’t look up. “You were thinking it.”

“I was NOT.”

“You paused before saying it. That’s consent.”

“That’s not how consent works.”

Mia shrugged. “In employment, it is.”

At noon, she made noodles.

Mia sat on the counter like it was her legal property.

“You’re applying too emotionally,” Mia said.

“How do you apply for jobs unemotionally?”

“You don’t care if they respond.”

“That sounds worse.”

“It is worse. But more efficient.”

She sighed. “I need experience.”

Mia pointed at her.

“You have experience.”

“In what?”

Mia smiled. “Surviving nonsense with no budget and zero supervision.”

She laughed despite herself.

“That’s not on LinkedIn.”

“It should be.”

At 2:37 p.m., she got a call.

Unknown number.

Her heart jumped like it had been waiting for permission.

She answered.

“Hello?”

A voice on the other end:

“Is this regarding your application?”

“Yes,” she said quickly.

Mia leaned closer. “Put it on speaker.”

She did.

“Can you tell us about your experience in customer handling?”

She froze.

Mia whispered: “Lie professionally.”

“I—uh—have extensive experience in communication, teamwork, and problem-solving.”

Mia nodded approvingly.

“That’s beautiful nonsense,” Mia whispered.

After the call ended, she sat in silence.

“That went okay,” she said.

Mia tilted her head. “It went average.”

“That’s better than bad.”

“It’s also worse than good.”

She groaned. “You’re impossible.”

"I'm employed in observation," Mia said proudly.

That evening, Mia insisted they "celebrate productivity."

Which meant sitting on the couch with snacks and pretending job applications counted as achievements.

"You applied to eight jobs," Mia said.

"Seven," she corrected.

"One was emotionally the same company," Mia said.

She narrowed her eyes. "That's not a metric."

"It is in capitalism."

Later, she opened her laptop again.

Scrolled through old folders.

Something felt... off.

Not wrong exactly.

Just slightly displaced.

Like a chair moved a few centimeters from where she remembered it being.

She clicked into her photo folder.

Graduation pictures.

Old school IDs.

Group photos.

She zoomed in on one.

A café picture from years ago—she thought.

She was sitting with someone.

Talking.

Laughing.

She squinted.

“Who is this?” she murmured.

Mia leaned over her shoulder.

“Oh, that was a good day.”

She blinked. “You were there?”

Mia nodded without hesitation. “Of course.”

She studied the photo again.

It felt familiar.

But also... incomplete.

There was no clear face beside her.

Just a blur where someone should have been.

“That’s weird,” she said slowly. “I don’t remember this.”

Mia shrugged. "You don't remember a lot of things correctly."

She laughed nervously. "That sounds concerning."

"It's not," Mia said lightly. "It's just selective storage."

"That's not how memory works."

Mia tapped her head. "Says the person who took four years longer than normal to graduate."

She frowned. "That's not the same thing."

Mia smiled. "Everything is connected if you look at it long enough."

That night, she tried to sleep early.

Didn't work.

Her mind kept replaying the photo.

The café.

The laughter.

The blur where a person should have been.

She turned to her side.

Mia was sitting on the edge of her bed.

Scrolling on her phone.

"Hey," she whispered.

Mia looked up. “Hmm?”

“Do you ever feel like… I forget things?”

Mia didn't answer immediately.

That was unusual.

Mia always answered immediately.

Then Mia smiled.

“Of course you do.”

“That's not what I mean.”

“I know,” Mia said softly.

Then she added, lighter again:

“That's why I'm here.”

She stared at her.

“That doesn't explain anything.”

“It's not supposed to,” Mia said. “It's supposed to help you sleep.”

She closed her eyes.

But sleep didn't come immediately.

Instead, she thought about something small.

Something she didn't expect to matter.

In the café photo—

why did she remember laughing with someone...

when the picture only showed her alone?

And in the quiet of her room,

Mia was still there.

Or at least—

she felt like she was.

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